

Several locations were suggested as potential settings for the peace negotiations, including Warsaw and Phnom Penh. However, after more than a month of discussion between Washington and Hanoi, it was decided the two parties would meet in Paris in the second week of May 1968. Officially called the International Conference on Vietnam, the talks unfolded at the Majestic Hotel near the Arc de Triomphe. Since French President Charles de Gaulle was hosting the meetings, it was determined that French would be the official language of the conference.

79 PERCENT Johnson's Gallup approval rating in 1964.
35 PERCENT Johnson's Gallup approval rating in 1968.



Historic setting

Delegates from both sides gather in May 1968, under the crystal chandeliers in the ballroom of the Hotel Majestic in Paris. Once a palace owned by Isabella II of Spain, the hotel belonged to the French government from 1936 to 2008.

Discussions stalled

William Averell Harriman, former US ambassador to the Soviet Union and Great Britain, headed up an American delegation that also included future secretary of state Cyrus Vance. On the other side of the table, the North Vietnamese team was led by former foreign minister Xuan Thuy, whom the US would soon come to view as a major obstacle to their goals during the peace process.

Diplomats on both sides hoped the talks would bring a quick end to the war in Indochina. However, weeks of negotiating yielded nothing, with both sides refusing to budge from their original positions.

The major sticking point for the US was the refusal of Xuan Thuy and his team to immediately withdraw all North Vietnamese troops from below the DMZ and recognize the legitimacy of the Saigon government. For the Hanoi delegation, the primary hurdles to reaching an agreement were the US delegates balking at a proposal to include the National Liberation Front in a coalition government in the South and the Saigon government's refusal to recognize the legitimacy of the Viet Cong. South Vietnamese President Thieu was a surprising impediment; US Ambassador Ellsworth Bunker made note to Johnson of "Thieu's sudden intransigence."